

BASF SE (BASF.DE): 2Q26 full release highlights structural transformation, focus on cash returns/deleveraging, and rising

Today (July 29) BASF released its full 2Q26 with EBITDA (b.s.i) coming in at €2,449mn (+18% vs. Vara Consensus - updated July 7th) with sales at €17,206mn (+5% vs. Vara Consensus). The company had already announced preliminary results on July 15, and today's results were in-line with the previously disclosed numbers (see [here](#)).

Divisions: On the volumes side, the biggest differences to consensus numbers were in the Chemicals division (+21% vs. consensus at +9%) and Nutrition & Care (+12% vs. consensus at +1%). Volumes beat consensus expectations across all divisions. Pricing at group level was below consensus expectations, the differences came mostly from Materials (+13% vs. consensus of +21%) as well as Nutrition & Care (-2% vs. consensus at +2%) and Agricultural Solutions (-3% vs. consensus at +1%). At the EBITDA level, Materials and Industrial Solutions were the main beats to consensus numbers (+28%/29% vs. consensus). The Corporate/Other division came in better than expectations on strong commodity trading results. Chemicals and Surface Technologies were the negative surprises with Chemicals margins -486bps below consensus expectations. All in, volumes came in stronger than expectations (+7.3% vs. consensus at +2.0%) while prices were below estimates (11.5% vs consensus at +12.7%).

Cash: Operating cash flow in the quarter was €524mn, down from €1,585mn in 2Q25 driven by higher receivables and inventory. The implied cash conversion (CFO/adj. EBITDA) for the quarter was 21% vs. 89% in 2Q25. Operating cash flow was also impacted by ~€200mn of cash transformation spending in relation to restructuring measures and new ERP systems in Agricultural Solutions. BASF expect higher earnings and lower capital expenditures to offset the higher working capital buildup for the full-year.

Outlook: BASF had already altered its FY26 guidance when it released its preliminary results - no incremental changes were made. EBITDA guidance stands at €6.9-7.7bn (from €6.2-7.0bn prior to the pre-release) vs. Vara Consensus at €7.3bn and GSe at €8.0bn, while free cash flow guidance is at €1.5bn-2.3bn vs. Vara Consensus €2.3bn and GSe at €1.36bn.

The conference call will be held at 07:30am UK time.

Georgina Fraser, Ph.D.
+44(20)7552-5984 |
georgina.fraser@gs.com
Goldman Sachs International

Marcus von Scheele
+44(20)7774-7676 |
marcus.vonscheele@gs.com
Goldman Sachs International

Thomas Ward
+44(20)7051-2527 |
thomas.ward@gs.com
Goldman Sachs International

Gabriel Simoes
+44(20)7051-6922 |
gabriel.simoes@gs.com
Goldman Sachs International

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Exhibit 1: BASF 2Q26 Actuals vs. GSe and Consensus

Volume and Price on Visible Alpha Consensus Data; Rest on Vara Consensus

BASF 2Q26 Results Review									
Interim results in EUR mn	Actual 2Q26	Cons 2Q26	Actual vs. cons	GSe Q226E	Actual vs. GS	Actual Q225	chg yoy	Actual Q126	chg qoq
P&L items (cont.)									
Chemicals	3,595	3,324	8.2%	2,906	23.7%	2,502	43.7%	2,662	35.0%
Materials	3,790	3,843	-1.4%	4,269	-11.2%	3,240	17.0%	3,238	17.0%
Industrial Solutions	2,328	2,283	2.0%	2,531	-8.0%	2,160	7.8%	2,092	11.3%
Surface Technologies	2,625	2,445	7.4%	2,082	26.1%	2,355	11.5%	2,409	9.0%
Nutrition & Care	1,709	1,675	2.0%	1,600	6.8%	1,618	5.6%	1,669	2.4%
Agricultural Solutions	2,210	2,146	3.0%	2,288	-3.4%	2,198	0.5%	3,104	-28.8%
Corporate/Other	948	760	24.7%	787	20.5%	715	32.6%	849	11.7%
Sales	17,206	16,462	4.5%	16,462	4.5%	14,788	16.4%	16,023	7.4%
Chemicals	377	510	-26.1%	494	-23.7%	209	80.4%	233	61.8%
Materials	792	617	28.4%	693	14.3%	408	94.1%	511	55.0%
Industrial Solutions	434	337	28.8%	448	-3.1%	307	41.4%	361	20.2%
Surface Technologies	115	182	-36.8%	148	-22.2%	172	-33.1%	275	-58.2%
Nutrition & Care	204	192	6.3%	205	-0.7%	196	4.1%	192	6.3%
Agricultural Solutions	448	386	16.1%	430	4.1%	417	7.4%	1,102	-59.3%
Corporate/Other	80	-142	156.3%	-99	-180.6%	-114	-170.2%	-319	-125.1%
Adj. EBITDA	2,449	2,082	17.6%	2,319	5.6%	1,595	53.5%	2,355	4.0%
<i>Adj. EBITDA margin</i>	<i>14.2%</i>	<i>12.6%</i>	<i>159 bps</i>	<i>14.1%</i>	<i>15 bps</i>	<i>10.8%</i>	<i>345 bps</i>	<i>14.7%</i>	<i>-46 bps</i>
EBITDA (reported)	1,965	2,032	-3.3%	2,256	-12.9%	1,318	49.1%	2,186	-10.1%
<i>EBITDA (reported) margin</i>	<i>11.4%</i>	<i>12.3%</i>	<i>-92 bps</i>	<i>13.7%</i>	<i>-229 bps</i>	<i>8.9%</i>	<i>251 bps</i>	<i>13.6%</i>	<i>-222 bps</i>
Adj. EBIT	685	1,081	-36.6%	1,453	-52.9%	685	0.0%	1,434	-52.2%
<i>Adj. EBIT margin</i>	<i>4.0%</i>	<i>6.6%</i>	<i>-259 bps</i>	<i>8.8%</i>	<i>-485 bps</i>	<i>4.6%</i>	<i>-65 bps</i>	<i>8.9%</i>	<i>-497 bps</i>
EPS (adj.)	1.28	0.85	50.6%	0.84	52.9%	0.48	164.5%	1.32	-3.2%
Balance sheet items									
Net interest bearing debt (period end)	17,117			20,858	-17.9%	21,337	-19.8%	20,580	-16.8%
Cashflow items									
Cash from operations	524			1,300	-59.7%	1,585	-66.9%	-797	-165.7%
Capex expenditure	-713			-909	-21.5%	-1,053	-32.3%	-578	23.4%
FCF	-189			391	-148%	532	-136%	-1,375	-86.3%
Volume % (y/y, cont.)									
Chemicals	20.7%	8.5%	1218 bps	4%	1718 bps	-1%	2130 bps	11%	930 bps
Materials	4.6%	2.9%	169 bps	2%	260 bps	2%	310 bps	4%	30 bps
Industrial Solutions	4.9%	1.0%	389 bps	3%	228 bps	-3%	750 bps	1%	350 bps
Surface Technologies	-0.6%	-3.9%	326 bps	3%	-323 bps	13%	-1340 bps	-1%	70 bps
Nutrition & Care	12.3%	1.1%	1117 bps	-5%	1686 bps	-4%	1620 bps	9%	340 bps
Agricultural Solutions	4.0%	-1.5%	545 bps	-3%	700 bps	21%	-1710 bps	3%	130 bps
Group	7.3%	2.0%	533 bps	1%	636 bps	4%	325 bps	5%	277 bps
Pricing % (y/y, cont.)									
Chemicals	23.8%	25.5%	-166 bps	13%	1080 bps	-12%	3620 bps	-14%	3770 bps
Materials	13.3%	20.7%	-738 bps	30%	-1671 bps	-3%	1670 bps	-5%	1850 bps
Industrial Solutions	4.2%	5.9%	-174 bps	15%	-1079 bps	-2%	660 bps	-4%	820 bps
Surface Technologies	19.3%	11.4%	790 bps	-9%	2808 bps	4%	1580 bps	26%	-630 bps
Nutrition & Care	-1.7%	2.3%	-400 bps	3%	-508 bps	3%	-500 bps	-5%	330 bps
Agricultural Solutions	-2.5%	1.4%	-391 bps	6%	-850 bps	-2%	-90 bps	-1%	-200 bps
Group	11.5%	12.7%	-121 bps	11%	12 bps	-3%	1451 bps	-1%	1277 bps
Adj. EBITDA margins % (cont.)									
Chemicals	10.5%	15.3%	-486 bps	17.0%	-651 bps	8.4%	213 bps	8.8%	173 bps
Materials	20.9%	16.1%	484 bps	16.2%	467 bps	12.6%	830 bps	15.8%	512 bps
Industrial Solutions	18.6%	14.8%	388 bps	17.7%	95 bps	14.2%	443 bps	17.3%	139 bps
Surface Technologies	4.4%	7.4%	-306 bps	7.1%	-272 bps	7.3%	-292 bps	11.4%	-703 bps
Nutrition & Care	11.9%	11.5%	47 bps	12.8%	-90 bps	12.1%	-18 bps	11.5%	43 bps
Agricultural Solutions	20.3%	18.0%	228 bps	18.8%	146 bps	19.0%	130 bps	35.5%	-1523 bps
Corporate/Other	8.4%	-18.7%	2712 bps	-12.6%	2106 bps	-15.9%	2438 bps	-37.6%	4601 bps

Source: Company data, Vara Research, Visible Alpha Consensus Data, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

GS View

Limited incremental vs. the ad hoc but we expect investors will perceive the magnitude of the “Other” driven beat (mainly from commodity trading business gains) as lower quality. That said the strength of performance in Ag and Industrial Solutions we find higher quality than expected and more sustainable. Details on the weaker cashflow highlight BASF transformation costs weighing as well as working capital. The release highlights important structural changes taking place at BASF to set up for a more profitable future: 1) as of May 2026 FTE at BASF stood below 30,000 for the first time since 1954, 2) CoreShift targets 20% lower net cash fixed costs by 2029 vs. 2024 (the target is on cash fixed costs and a notable magnitude meaning it aims to go materially further than offsetting inflation, in our view). As long as management can reassure on its framework for determining “value creative M&A” we do not expect investors to be surprised by the more direct messaging re capital allocation (BASF states that the relative attractiveness of inorganic versus organic growth opportunities has increased).

Investors we speak to have been increasingly cautious on the shares even as geopolitical tensions started to rise again. We see little in the release to change the market’s perception that we have seen the peak quarterly momentum at 2Q26 and that destocking/margin compression lies ahead for the coming quarters. Any change in sentiment would have to come from better-than-expected current trading commentary on the conference call, in our view.

Valuation & Risks

Valuation

We are Buy rated on BASF, with a 12-month price target of €57. We value BASF using 9.75x EV/DACF. We derive our multiple by applying a factor of 0.97 to the historical EV/DACF multiple of 10.0x. The factor is below 1 as our forecast CROCI is lower vs. history.

Risks

Downside risks to our view and price target include:

- Weaker-than-expected demand in key end markets (automotive, construction, consumer goods) amid European recession or prolonged German industrial stagnation.
- Value-destructive M&A if BASF consolidates European chemical assets.
- Chinese chemical producers intensify competition on cost and capacity.
- Chinese monetary and fiscal stimulus fails to support domestic production and domestic chemical demand.
- BASF's Zhanjiang ramp is delayed and/or margins at the site remain subdued. This could lead to a lower-than-expected earnings contribution from the new businesses.
- Inability to pass through feedstock cost inflation compressing margins in upstream chemicals.
- Agricultural end markets weaken due to farmer economics and/or trade uncertainty.
- Continued structural erosion of European chemical competitiveness due to energy costs, regulatory burden and capital flight.
- Suez Canal fully reopens, lowering logistics costs and enabling an increase in Asian chemical imports into Europe.

BASFn.DE	12m Price Target: €57.00	Price: €48.97	Upside: 16.4%
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Buy		GS Forecast				
Market cap: €45.0bn / \$51.2bn Enterprise value: €66.6bn / \$75.8bn 3m ADTV: €122.0mn / \$141.1mn Germany Europe Chemicals M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes			12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
		Revenue (€ mn)	59,657.0	61,911.7	60,685.1	62,407.3
		EBIT (€ mn)	2,888.0	4,251.2	4,165.6	5,049.2
		EPS (€)	2.24	3.09	2.78	3.37
		P/E (X)	19.9	15.9	17.6	14.5
		EV/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	8.5	7.5	7.3	6.8
		Dividend yield (%)	5.1	4.9	6.1	6.1
		FCF yield (%)	3.3	3.0	7.3	8.3
		CROCI (%)	4.7	5.5	5.1	5.4
		N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	2.8	2.4	2.2	1.8
			12/25	3/26E	6/26E	9/26E
		EPS (€)	(1.39)	1.32	0.84	0.33

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 28 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

We, Georgina Fraser, Ph.D., Marcus von Scheele, Thomas Ward and Gabriel Simoes, hereby certify that all of the views expressed in this report accurately reflect our personal views about the subject company or companies and its or their securities. We also certify that no part of our compensation was, is or will be, directly or indirectly, related to the specific recommendations or views expressed in this report.

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Contributing Authors: Georgina Fraser, Ph.D. Goldman Sachs International, Marcus von Scheele Goldman Sachs International, Thomas Ward Goldman Sachs International, Gabriel Simoes Goldman Sachs International.

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Growth is based on a stock's forward-looking sales growth, EBITDA growth and EPS growth (for financial stocks, only EPS and sales growth), with a higher percentile indicating a higher growth company. **Financial Returns** is based on a stock's forward-looking ROE, ROCE and CROCI (for financial stocks, only ROE), with a higher percentile indicating a company with higher financial returns. **Multiple** is based on a stock's forward-looking P/E, P/B, price/dividend (P/D), EV/EBITDA, EV/FCF and EV/Debt Adjusted Cash Flow (DACF) (for financial stocks, only P/E, P/B and P/D), with a higher percentile indicating a stock trading at a higher multiple. The **Integrated** percentile is calculated as the average of the Growth percentile, Financial Returns percentile and (100% - Multiple percentile).

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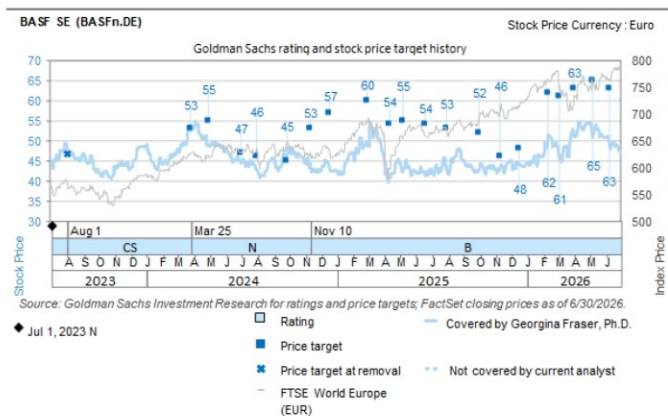
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Target price history table(s)

BASF SE (BASFn.DE)

Date of report Target price (€) Closing price (€)

01-Jul-26	57.00	46.80
08-Jun-26	63.00	48.85
08-May-26	65.00	51.65
01-Apr-26	63.00	50.94
04-Mar-26	61.00	46.15
10-Feb-26	62.00	50.92
16-Dec-25	48.00	44.52
11-Nov-25	46.00	43.57
01-Oct-25	52.00	42.81
31-Jul-25	53.00	43.16
19-Jun-25	54.00	41.45
08-May-25	55.00	42.86
11-Apr-25	54.00	40.74
28-Feb-25	60.00	49.21
18-Dec-24	57.00	43.39
11-Nov-24	53.00	44.28
27-Sep-24	45.00	48.28
30-Jul-24	46.00	42.77
30-Jun-24	47.00	45.19
29-Apr-24	55.00	49.06
25-Mar-24	53.00	52.93

Price targets shown in table(s) are unadjusted for corporate actions.

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